particularly important chief, Mir Masjidi Khan, the revered Naqsbandi Pir who was the most influential leader in the area, was actually on the verge of surrendering, and had given his word he would come into Kabul and 'take refuge in the mausoleum of Timur Shah, and thence proceed to wait upon the Shah and the Envoy'. Burnes had agreed to this, when 'contrary to previous arrangements' Sale and Prince Timur set off to besiege Mir Masjidi's fort. The fort at first proved too strong to storm, and the wounded and embittered Mir Masjidi managed to escape to Nijrow. In his absence his fort was destroyed, his family slaughtered and his lands distributed to his enemies. The brutality of the destruction of the fort and all its inhabitants horrified the Kohistanis. 'They broke down its walls,' wrote Ghulam Kohistani,

> In every gold-spangled house
> Bedecked like a spring garden
>
> They set fire to the doors and roofs
> Which carried their message up to the skies
>
> They destroyed the central arch
> They made it like a wasteland
>
> No one saw any sign of life
> No, no one had ever heard a more devastating tale[94]

Thus, concluded Mohan Lal, 'we made the Mir our enemy for ever'.[95] In due course, Mir Masjidi would return and succeed in driving the British out of Kohistan, pursuing the last survivors of the garrison to Kabul. Making an enemy out of him was one of the most serious errors made by the British in the whole campaign.

In mid-October, matters took another turn for the worse when a whole squadron of British-trained Kohistani troops in Charikar crossed over and joined Dost Mohammad.[96] Mohan Lal thought that this was one of the most serious threats the British would ever face in their occupation of Afghanistan, with the Amir on the loose, Kohistan in flames and the rest of the tribes waiting to see who would come out victorious, 'the people and chiefs being equally discontented by our not adhering to the engagements and promises we had made them'.[97]